



Character Abilities

After rolling the six ability scores for a character, the player should choose a **class** — that type of adventurer which the player would most like the character to be. One or two abilities are the most important to each character class. The ability most important to a class is called the **prime requisite** for that class. The higher the prime requisite score, the more successful that character will be in that class.

To choose a class, a player should first look for his or her highest ability scores. If one of the high scores is the prime requisite for a class, the player should consider making his or her character a member of that class.

The six ability scores, and their use as prime requisite, are explained hereafter:

Strength: “Strength” is a measure of muscle power and the ability to use that power. Any character with a Strength score of 13 or above should consider one of the following four classes: fighter, dwarf, elf, or halfling. Strength is the prime requisite for the classes of fighter and dwarf, and one of the two prime requisites for the classes of elf and halfling.

Intelligence: “Intelligence” is the ability to learn and remember knowledge, and the ability to solve problems. Characters with an intelligence score of 13 or above should consider the classes of magic-user or elf. Intelligence is the prime requisite for magic-users, and one of the prime requisites for elves.

Wisdom: The word “Wisdom” refers to inspiration, intuition, common sense, and shrewdness. Wisdom aids in solving problems when Intelligence is not enough. A character with a Wisdom score of 13 or greater should consider the class of cleric, since Wisdom is the prime requisite of that class.

Dexterity: “Dexterity” is a measure of speed and agility. A character with a high Dexterity score is “good with his hands” and has a good sense of balance. A character with a Dexterity score of 13 or greater should consider the classes of thief and halfling. Dexterity is the prime requisite of thieves and one of the prime requisites of halflings.

Constitution: “Constitution” is a combination of health and endurance (the ability to hold up under pressure). It directly influences every class, possibly changing the number of hit points a character has. Constitution is never a prime requisite.

Charisma: “Charisma” is a combination of appearance, personal charm, and leadership ability. It helps the DM decide exactly how a monster will react to a player character. It also affects the number of **retainers** a character can hire (see page B21), and the **morale** (attitude; see page B27) of these hirelings. Charisma is never a prime requisite.

Ability Score Adjustments

It is possible to raise one’s score in a prime requisite by lowering the scores of some of the other abilities. This adjustment shows that a character may practice hard and learn how to fight or reason well, but at the cost of not developing another ability.

When adjusting abilities, no score may be lowered below 9. When an adjustment is made, a prime requisite ability will be raised 1 point for every 2 points that the adjusted ability is lowered.

Strength may be lowered by magic-users in order to raise Intelligence, and by clerics in order to raise Wisdom.

Intelligence may be lowered by fighters, dwarves, halflings, thieves, and clerics in order to raise a prime requisite of their class.

Wisdom may be lowered by magic-users, fighters, dwarves, elves, halflings, and thieves in order to raise a prime requisite for their class.

Dexterity may not be lowered, though it can be raised if it is a prime requisite.

Constitution and **Charisma** may not be raised or lowered.

For example, a magic-user might lower a Strength score of 15 to 9 (a drop of 6) in order to raise an Intelligence score of 15 to 18 (a raise of $6/2 = 3$).

Hit Points and Hit Dice

Hit points represent the number of “points” of damage a character or monster can take during battle before dying. Any creature reduced to 0 hit points (or less) is dead. The combat process is explained in **Part 5: THE ENCOUNTER** (under pages B24-28). For now, it is enough to realize that the more hit points a character has, the better the chance he or she has to survive a battle. On the average, fighters and dwarves will have the most hit points; clerics, halflings, and elves will have an average number of hit points; and magic-users and thieves will have the least hit points.

ROLLING HIT POINTS: Each time a character earns enough experience points to gain a new level, the character gets to roll for more hit points. When starting out, each character rolls one hit die, using the type of die given for the character class. Upon reaching second level, the character rolls the same type of die a second time and adds the result to the first roll. This process is repeated for each new level. The result of each new hit die roll is *always* added to the total of the other hit die rolls.

(First level characters may easily be killed in battle. As an option, the DM may allow a player character to roll again if the player has rolled a 1 or 2 for the number of hit points at first level only.)